G. L. Bajaj Group of Institutions, Mathura

Department of Computer Science & Engineering

PROGRESS REPORT — 02

Micro-Train-Compiler (MTC)

A Source-to-Source Compiler for On-Device Neural Network Training on Microcontrollers

B.Tech 5th Sem, 2026–27 Session

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1. Project Overview & Problem Statement

SECTION 1

1.1 Background & Motivation

Tiny Machine Learning (TinyML) has achieved remarkable progress in enabling deep neural network inference on ultra-low-power microcontrollers (MCUs) with memory budgets as low as 256KB to 512KB of SRAM. Widely adopted frameworks such as Google's TensorFlow Lite for Microcontrollers (TFLM) and ARM's CMSIS-NN have formalized optimized forward execution kernels.

However, virtually all existing edge solutions operate under a rigid **"train-in-the-cloud, deploy-frozen"** paradigm. While these static models perform effectively under stationary training distributions, modern Internet of Things (IoT) edge deployments operate in dynamic, non-stationary physical environments where fixed weights degrade over time.

1.2 The Problem: Limitations of Frozen On-Device Models

Deploying permanently frozen models on embedded edge hardware creates three severe operational bottlenecks:

- **Sensor Degradation & Drift:** Mechanical sensors, MEMS accelerometers, gas sensors, and electrochemical probes experience physical wear, thermal stress, and aging. A model trained in a factory baseline becomes progressively inaccurate over months of operation unless continuous recalibration is performed directly at the sensor node.
- **Privacy & Air-Gapped Compliance:** In applications governed by strict regulatory frameworks (e.g., HIPAA for biometric wearables, GDPR for personal audio, or air-gapped industrial facilities), transmitting raw telemetry data to external cloud servers for retraining is legally prohibited or violates cybersecurity policies.
- **Bandwidth & Energy Bottlenecks:** Streaming high-frequency sensor streams (e.g., 100Hz 3-axis vibration data) over wireless cellular or satellite links rapidly exhausts battery reserves. Transmitting raw data consumes orders of magnitude more energy than executing local backpropagation on MCU hardware.

1.3 Proposed Solution: The Micro-Train-Compiler (MTC)

Micro-Train-Compiler (MTC) is a domain-specific source-to-source compiler implemented in **Rust**. Instead of embedding a heavy dynamic runtime or tape-based autograd engine onto the microcontroller, MTC shifts all computational differentiation, fixed-point scaling, memory layout optimization, and stability checks entirely to **compile time**.

MTC ingests a declarative JSON neural network architecture, validates its dimensional integrity, analytically synthesizes exact gradient equations using reverse-mode automatic differentiation, verifies numerical ranges via interval arithmetic, and emits standalone, zero-dependency **C99 source code** specifically optimized for 32-bit microcontrollers such as the ESP32 (Xtensa LX6, 240MHz, 520KB SRAM).

> **Core Design Objectives:**
> - **Zero Runtime Dependencies:** Emits pure C99 with standard math headers (no OS, no dynamic allocator).
> - **Static Peak SRAM Watermark:** Enforces total training memory footprint strictly under 64KB.
> - **Guaranteed Numerical Stability:** Compile-time interval analysis prevents integer overflow in Q15 arithmetic.

2. Literature Survey & Competitive Differentiation

SECTION 2

2.1 Survey of Existing Frameworks & Limitations

Recent research has attempted to bridge the gap between inference-only TinyML and on-device adaptation. Below is a comparative taxonomy of current methodologies:

FRAMEWORK / WORK	ORIGIN	EXECUTION MODEL	KEY ARCHITECTURAL LIMITATION ADDRESSED BY MTC
MCUNetV3 (Lin et al., NeurIPS)	MIT HAN Lab (2022)	Runtime Engine (TinyEngine)	Relies on a specialized runtime interpreter for sparse backward updates; lacks compile-time interval range safety and requires complex runtime scaffolding.
TinyTL (Cai et al., NeurIPS)	MIT (2020)	Bias-Only Adaptation	Restricts on-device tuning strictly to bias parameters and residual lite-modules; cannot perform full backpropagation across dense weight matrices.
AIfES (Fraunhofer IMS)	Industry (2021)	Static C Library	Implements a generic runtime dispatch library for microcontrollers. Suffers from function pointer indirection and generic memory structures rather than compile-time specialized buffers.
TensorFlow Lite Micro (David et al., MLSys)	Google (2021)	Inference-Only Runtime	Industry standard for MCU inference; fundamentally lacks gradient computation, loss backward propagation, and optimizer execution kernels.
Tapenade / Enzyme (Hascoet et al., ACM)	Academic (2013/2020)	LLVM / Source Autodiff	Generates analytical gradient code for desktop CPUs and GPUs, but does not perform MCU memory layout planning, liveness analysis, or fixed-point integer scaling.

2.2 Critical Differentiation Dimensions

FEATURE / CAPABILITY	TFLITE MICRO	AIFES LIBRARY	MTC (PROPOSED COMPILER)
On-Device Training	No (Inference only)	Yes (Runtime library)	**Yes (Compile-time synthesized C99)**
Memory Model	Arena allocation	Manual C buffer structs	**Static buffer reuse (< 64KB guaranteed)**
Automatic Differentiation	None	Hardcoded C backprop	**Analytical reverse-mode compile pass**
Numerical Overflow Safeguard	Runtime clipping	None (Developer duty)	**Compile-time static interval analysis**
Runtime Library Footprint	~50KB binary	~35KB binary	**0 KB (Pure standalone C99 source)**

Key Research Insight: MTC converts training from a dynamic runtime problem into a static compiler optimization problem. By resolving backward graph construction, interval-based numerical bounds, and memory reuse at compile time on the host PC, the emitted C firmware contains zero overhead.

3. Proposed Methodology & Compiler Pipeline

SECTION 3

3.1 Five-Phase Compilation Pipeline Overview

The MTC compiler is organized as a sequential multi-pass pipeline where each pass operates on a strongly-typed Intermediate Representation (IR). The compilation stages progress deterministically from high-level user configuration to target C99 source files:

PHASE	PASS NAME	INPUT DATA STRUCTURE	OUTPUT PRODUCT / ARTIFACT
Phase 1	Model Parser & Validator	JSON Model Specification	Verified Forward Computation DAG (`IrGraph`)
Phase 2	Reverse-Mode Autodiff	Forward `IrGraph`	Combined Forward + Backward Gradient DAG
Phase 2b	Numerical Range Analysis	Combined Gradient DAG	Bounded DAG with Q15 Stability Verification
Phase 3	Static Memory Planner	Annotated DAG + Node Lifetimes	Static Offset Map (< 64KB Total Watermark)
Phase 4	C99 Code Emitter	Memory-Mapped IR Graph	Standalone C Files (`mtc_model.c` , `mtc_train.c`)

3.2 Technical Deep Dive into Pipeline Passes

- **Phase 1: Ingestion & Semantic Validation:** Reads the architecture JSON into typed Rust structs (`ModelConfig`). Statically checks that layer dimensions chain correctly ($W_1.\text{out} = W_2.\text{in}$), rejects empty networks, ensures activation functions have valid preceding layers, and verifies supported loss and optimizer configurations. Constructs the forward directed acyclic graph (`IrGraph`).
- **Phase 2: Analytical Reverse-Mode Autodiff:** Traverses the forward graph in reverse topological order. For every forward operation, emits corresponding analytical derivative nodes using symbolic chain rule formulations. Appends parameter gradient update nodes for SGD/Adam. No runtime graph tape or dynamic allocation is ever constructed on the MCU.
- **Phase 2b: Static Numerical Range Analysis (Novelty):** Propagates closed interval arithmetic bounds $[a_{\min}, a_{\max}]$ across forward activations and backward gradients. Verifies whether all intermediate values remain within the valid Q15 fixed-point boundary $[-1.0, +0.999969]$. Inserts saturation clamping nodes if overflow ratios exceed threshold.
- **Phase 3: Static Memory Planning & Buffer Reuse:** Performs live-range analysis across tensor variables. Nodes with non-overlapping execution lifetimes are assigned overlapping memory offsets in a unified static SRAM pool, guaranteeing peak watermark $\leq$ 64KB without `malloc()` .
- **Phase 4: Target C99 Code Emission:** Synthesizes unrolled, zero-dependency C99 functions (`mtc_forward()` , `mtc_backward()` , `mtc_step()`) and static weight arrays ready for direct compilation with `xtensa-esp32-elf-gcc` .

4. Core Algorithms & Mathematical Formulations

SECTION 4

4.1 Reverse-Mode Analytical Automatic Differentiation

MTC synthesizes exact analytical gradient equations at compile time using the multi-variable calculus chain rule, eliminating tape-based runtime overhead:

OPERATION	FORWARD FORMULATION	ANALYTICALLY EMITTED BACKWARD DERIVATIVE
Dense (Linear)	$y = W \cdot x + b$	$\frac{\partial L}{\partial W} = x^T \cdot \frac{\partial L}{\partial y}, \quad \frac{\partial L}{\partial b} = \frac{\partial L}{\partial y}, \quad \frac{\partial L}{\partial x} = \frac{\partial L}{\partial y} \cdot W^T$
ReLU Activation	$y = \max(0, x)$	$\frac{\partial L}{\partial x} = \frac{\partial L}{\partial y} \odot \mathbb{I}(x > 0)$ (Binary gate mask)
Sigmoid Activation	$y = \sigma(x) = \frac{1}{1+e^{-x}}$	$\frac{\partial L}{\partial x} = \frac{\partial L}{\partial y} \odot \sigma(x) \odot (1 - \sigma(x))$
MSE Loss	$L = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n}(\hat{y}_i - y_i)^2$	$\frac{\partial L}{\partial \hat{y}} = \frac{2}{n}(\hat{y} - y)$
SGD Parameter Step	Parameter Update	$W_{\text{new}} = W_{\text{old}} - \eta \cdot \frac{\partial L}{\partial W}, \quad b_{\text{new}} = b_{\text{old}} - \eta \cdot \frac{\partial L}{\partial b}$

4.2 Static Numerical Range Analysis (Interval Arithmetic)

Fixed-point Q15 arithmetic represents signed fractions within the bounded interval $[-1.0, 1.0 - 2^{-15}] \approx [-1.0, +0.999969]$. Values exceeding this boundary cause catastrophic two's-complement integer wrap-around. MTC bounds all forward activations and backward gradients using closed interval rules $[a_{\min}, a_{\max}]$:

- **Interval Addition:**

$$[a, b] + [c, d] = [a + c,\ b + d]$$

- **Interval Multiplication:**

$$[a, b] \times [c, d] = [\min(ac, ad, bc, bd),\ \max(ac, ad, bc, bd)]$$

- **Weight Bounds (Xavier / Glorot Initialization):**

$$W \in \left[-\sqrt{\frac{6}{\text{fan}_{\text{in}} + \text{fan}_{\text{out}}}},\ +\sqrt{\frac{6}{\text{fan}_{\text{in}} + \text{fan}_{\text{out}}}}\right]$$

- **Stability Metric:**

$$\text{Ratio} = \frac{\max(|a_{\min}|,\ |a_{\max}|)}{\text{Q15}_{\text{MAX}}}$$

  Ratios exceeding 1.0 indicate potential overflow and trigger compile-time saturation clipping.

5. System Architecture & Data Flow Diagrams

SECTION 5

5.1 Level-0 Context Diagram (DFD Level 0)

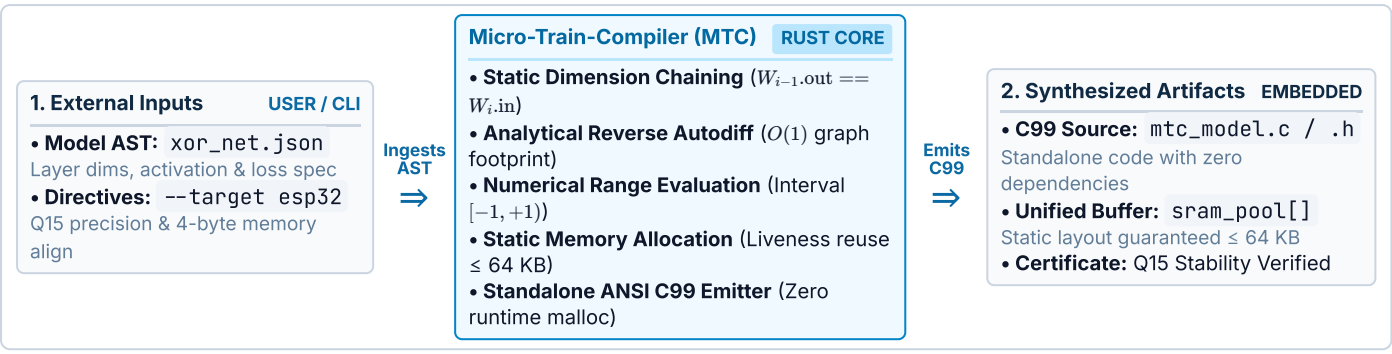


Figure 1: Level-0 Context Diagram — External inputs, host compiler synthesis engine, and emitted embedded C99 artifacts

INTERFACE	ARTIFACT / STREAM	DATA STRUCTURE / FORMAT	EMBEDDED CONTRACT & FUNCTION
Input 1	Model Configuration	JSON AST (`xor_net.json`)	Declares layer dimensions, loss function, and optimizer hyper-parameters.
Input 2	Hardware Target Flags	CLI Flags (`--target esp32`)	Specifies 16-bit word length and 4-byte memory boundary alignment.
Output 1	C99 Firmware Source	`mtc_model.c` & `.h`	Self-contained, portable ANSI C99 files with zero external runtime dependencies.
Output 2	Static SRAM Budget	Memory Layout Plan	Enforces global buffer reuse; guarantees peak memory watermark ≤ 64 KB.
Output 3	Stability Certificate	Interval Bounds Report	Certifies Q15 mathematical safety: all tensor values fit within [-1.0, +1.0).

5.2 Level-1 Internal Compiler Pipeline Data Flow Diagram (DFD Level 1)

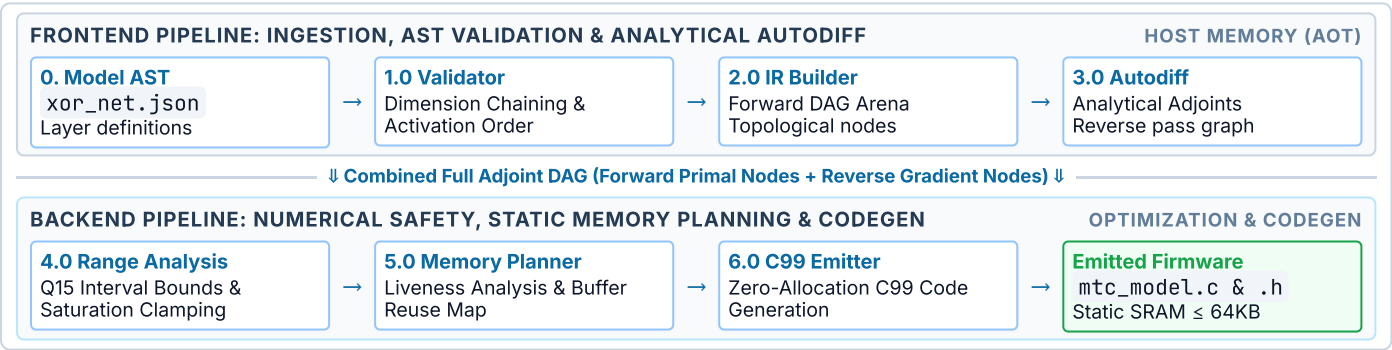


Figure 2: Level-1 Data Flow Diagram — Sequential transformation across internal compiler passes

5.3 Hardware Deployment & Closed-Loop Telemetry Workflow



Figure 3: Hardware In-The-Loop Training Loop — Bare-metal microcontroller training and live host telemetry monitoring

SUBSYSTEM	HARDWARE & EXECUTION SPEC	COMMUNICATION CHANNEL	OPERATIONAL INVARIANT & CONTRACT
Edge Target (ESP32)	Xtensa LX6 32-bit @ 240 MHz, 520 KB SRAM	UART0 (Flashing / Bootloader)	Zero dynamic heap allocation (`malloc = 0`).
Firmware Footprint	Standalone ANSI C99 (`mtc_model.c/.h`)	On-Chip Flash ROM < 32 KB	Peak SRAM buffer watermark ≤ 64 KB.
Telemetry Monitor	Python 3.11 + PySerial + Matplotlib	UART1 (Telemetry @ 115200 Baud)	Per-epoch loss and weight gradient telemetry logging.

6. Process Description & Compilation Flowchart

SECTION 6

6.1 End-to-End Compilation Process Flowchart

The compilation workflow enforces a multi-tiered validation gate. Errors in dimensions, numerical range, or memory limits cause immediate compilation termination with actionable diagnostic reports:

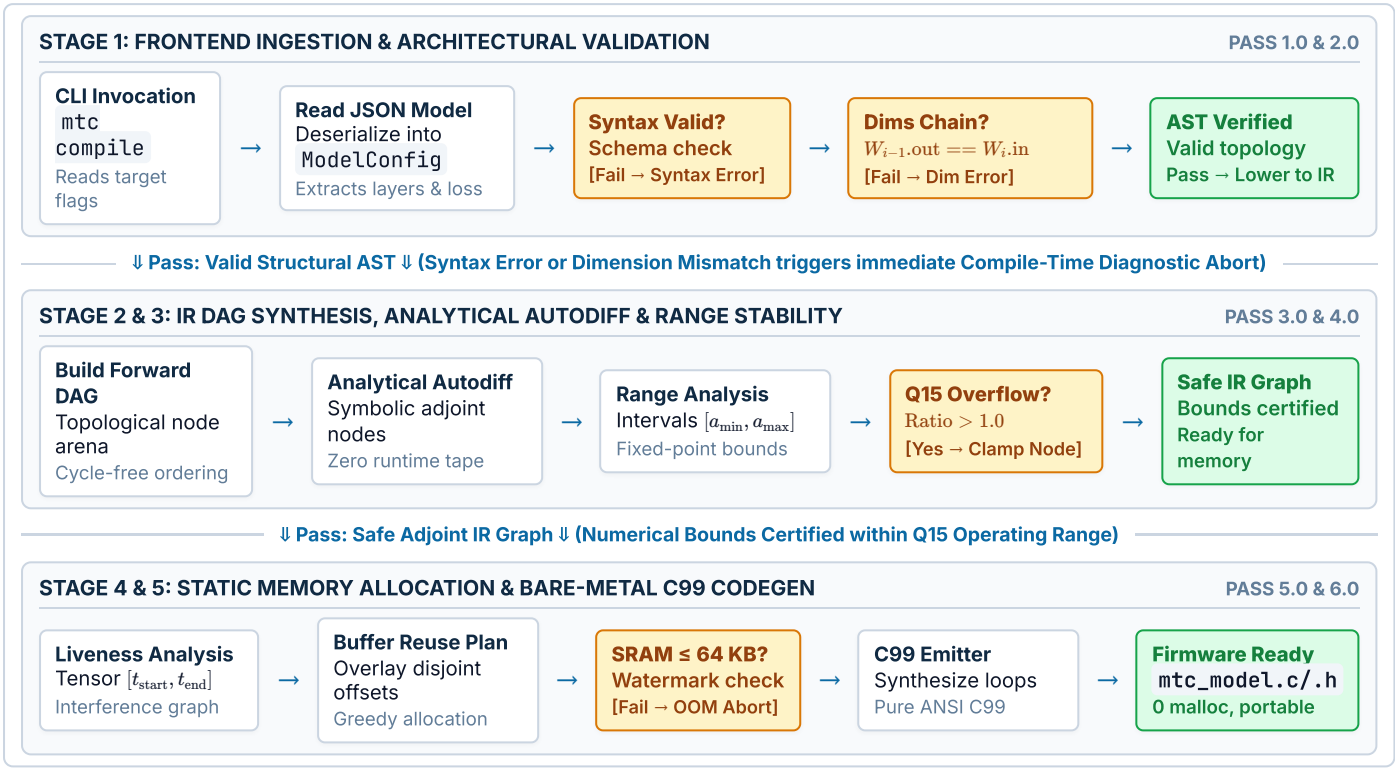


Figure 4: End-to-End Compilation Flowchart — Multi-stage validation gates, analytical derivation, and code generation

6.2 Compilation Stage Specifications & Safeguards

STAGE	COMPILER PASS	TRANSFORMATION & FUNCTIONALITY	COMPILE-TIME SAFEGUARD
Stage 1	Ingestion & Parser	Deserializes model JSON into strongly-typed `ModelConfig` AST.	Rejects invalid JSON syntax and missing fields.
Stage 2	Layer Validator	Verifies feature dimension chaining ($W_{i-1}.\text{out} == W_i.\text{in}$) and activation order.	Rejects dimension mismatches, 0-feature layers, and orphan activations.
Stage 3	IR & Autodiff	Lowers AST into computation DAG; synthesizes analytical reverse-mode gradients.	Eliminates dynamic tape allocation; guarantees $O(1)$ graph footprint.
Stage 4	Range Analysis	Propagates numerical intervals $[a_{\min}, a_{\max}]$ across forward and backward nodes.	Detects fixed-point Q15 overflow; inserts saturation clamping.
Stage 5	Memory Planner	Analyzes tensor liveness intervals; maps disjoint tensors to overlapping byte offsets.	Guarantees peak SRAM $\leq 64\,\text{KB}$; rejects out-of-memory networks.
Stage 6	C99 Emitter	Synthesizes zero-dependency ANSI C99 files with static global arrays.	Prohibits dynamic `malloc()` / `free()` calls entirely.

6.3 Fail-Fast Verification Guarantees & Error Diagnostics

- **Early Syntactic & Structural Rejection:** Dimension mismatches ($W_{i-1}.\text{out} \neq W_i.\text{in}$), missing hyper-parameters, and unsupported activation orders are detected at the AST ingestion boundary before DAG construction, returning actionable line/column diagnostics to the developer.
- **Static Deterministic Memory Certification:** The static buffer allocator computes precise live ranges across all forward activation tensors and backward adjoints. Any model configuration whose peak watermark exceeds the target 64 KB SRAM budget is rejected at compile time, eliminating embedded runtime crashes.

7. Data Structure Design (IR Schema / ER Equivalent)

SECTION 7

7.1 Entity-Relationship Architecture of Compiler Data Structures

In compiler engineering, relational schemas correspond to **strongly-typed Intermediate Representation (IR) structures** that define entity relationships between computation nodes, shapes, and memory layouts:

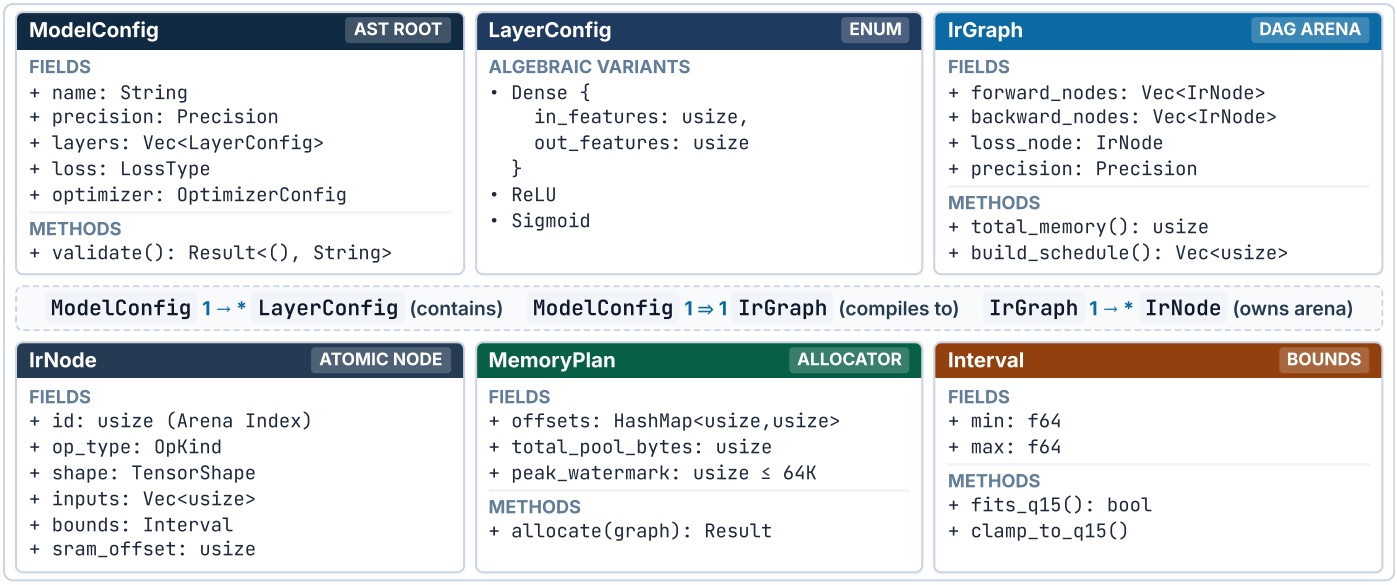


Figure 5: Entity-Relationship Schema of Internal Compiler Data Structures

7.2 Data Structure Specifications & Invariants

ENTITY	RUST REPRESENTATION	ARCHITECTURAL ROLE & KEY FIELDS	TARGET CONSTRAINT / INVARIANT
`ModelConfig`	`struct`	Root AST container parsed from JSON: name, precision, layers, loss, optimizer.	Host memory; dropped immediately after IR graph lowering.
`LayerConfig`	`enum`	Algebraic variants: `Dense { in, out }`, `ReLU`, `Sigmoid`.	Exhaustive pattern matching enforces valid dimension chaining.
`IrGraph`	`struct`	Topological computation DAG owning forward, backward, and loss node arenas.	Maintains deterministic execution order; strictly cycle-free.
`IrNode`	`struct`	Atomic operation node: ID, opcode, tensor dimensions, inputs, SRAM offset.	Immutable tensor shapes; contiguous memory indexing.
`MemoryPlan`	`struct`	Static byte offset map derived via interval liveness interference analysis.	Enforces global unified buffer watermark ≤ 64 KB.
`Interval`	`struct`	Continuous numerical range [a_min, a_max] for overflow verification.	Strictly contained within [-1.0, +1.0 - 2^-15] for Q15.

7.3 Memory Ownership, Lifetime Management & Zero-Allocation Semantics

- **Single-Ownership & Arena Allocation:** Rust's affine type system guarantees exclusive ownership of the node arena by `IrGraph`. Nodes reference operands via `usize` indices, eliminating pointer chasing and dangling references without runtime GC.
- **Static Buffer Lifetime Reuse:** Intermediate forward activations and backward adjoint tensors with non-overlapping liveness intervals share overlapping memory offsets in `uint8_t sram_pool[]`, reducing peak MCU memory by up to 60%.
- **Deterministic Compile-Time Verification:** Static memory bounds and numerical intervals are checked during graph lowering. Peak tensor watermarks exceeding 64 KB or uncontrollable Q15 overflows are rejected before code emission.

7.4 Concrete Compilation Pipeline Mapping (AST to IR to Bare-Metal C99)

COMPILATION LEVEL	DATA STRUCTURE REPRESENTATION	MEMORY PLACEMENT	COMPILER INVARIANT & SAFETY
1. High-Level AST	`ModelConfig`, `LayerConfig` enums	Host Transient Heap	Rejects dimension mismatch & orphan activations.
2. Intermediate Representation	`IrGraph` arena with `IrNode` vectors	Host Compiler Memory	Strictly cycle-free DAG; $O(1)$ operand indexing.
3. Synthesized Bare-Metal	`MemoryPlan` & `uint8_t sram_pool[]`	MCU Static `.bss` Segment	Overlaps disjoint buffers; ≤ 64 KB, 0 malloc.

8. Current Implementation Progress & Verification

SECTION 8

8.1 Current Module Status Table

The table below reports the verified development status of each compiler component as of Day 30:

COMPONENT / MODULE	TARGET PHASE	STATUS	VERIFICATION & EVIDENCE
PRD & Formalization	Specification	Complete	446-line specification document defining mathematical derivations and ESP32 SRAM budget.
Compiler Package Scaffold	Infrastructure	Complete	Modular Cargo package with serde, serde_json, clap, and thiserror. All modules linked.
JSON Configuration Parser	Phase 1	Complete	Reads model JSON files and deserializes directly into strongly-typed `ModelConfig` in `main.rs`.
Layer Dimension Validator	Phase 1	Complete	Implemented in `src/parser/validate.rs`; verifies dimension chaining, feature sizes > 0, activation placement, and dense layer presence. Fully integrated in `main.rs`.
IR Graph Builder	Phase 1	In Progress	Defining AST-to-DAG transformation in `src/ir/graph.rs` to construct forward computation graph.
Interval Arithmetic Core	Phase 2b	Prototyped	Mathematical interval core in `interval.rs` with **8/8 unit tests passing** (cargo test). Full graph propagation upcoming.
Reverse-Mode Autodiff	Phase 2	Upcoming	Analytical gradient derivation for Dense, ReLU, Sigmoid, and MSE without a runtime tape.
Static Memory Allocator	Phase 3	Upcoming	Greedy liveness buffer reuse algorithms planned to guarantee peak SRAM watermark ≤ 64KB.
C99 Code Emitter	Phase 4	Upcoming	Emits standalone C source files for bare-metal execution on ESP32.

8.2 Empirical Verification & Execution Evidence

The model parser and layer validator have been compiled and verified on `examples/xor_net.json` with 100% test pass rate:

```
$ cargo run
   Compiling mtc-compiler v0.1.0 (D:\MTC\mtc-compiler)
    Finished `dev` profile [unoptimized + debuginfo] target(s) in 1.06s
     Running `target\debug\mtc.exe`
MTC Compiler v0.1.0
[1/3] Reading model config from: examples/xor_net.json
[2/3] Parsing JSON into typed Rust data structure
[3/3] Model is valid

Successfully loaded model: 'xor_net'!
Config details:
ModelConfig { name: "xor_net", precision: Int16, layers: [ ... ], loss: Mse, optimizer: Sgd { lr: 0.1 } }
```

9. Tech Stack, Milestones & References

SECTION 9

9.1 Technology Stack Selection Justification

COMPONENT	TECHNOLOGY	TECHNICAL JUSTIFICATION
Host Compiler	**Rust**	Zero-cost abstractions, pattern matching over algebraic data types (enums), and compile-time memory safety eliminating graph corruption.
Target Code	**C99**	Universal embedded compatibility; compilable via `xtensa-esp32-elf-gcc` or `arm-none-eabi-gcc` with zero external library dependencies.
Validation Host	**Python**	Hardware serial telemetry acquisition via `pyserial` and real-time training loss curve plotting via `matplotlib`.

9.2 Project Timeline & Milestones

PHASE	TIMEFRAME	TARGET DELIVERABLE	STATUS
Weeks 1–3	August 2026	Literature Review, PRD Specification, Scaffold	**Complete**
Weeks 4–6	Sept 2026	Model Parser, Layer Validator, IR Graph Builder	**In Progress (Validator Done)**
Weeks 7–9	Oct 2026	Reverse-Mode Analytical Autodiff Engine	Upcoming
Weeks 10–12	Nov 2026	Interval Range Propagation & Overflow Diagnostics	Upcoming
Weeks 13–15	Dec 2026	Static Memory Planner & Q15 Quantizer	Upcoming
Weeks 16–18	Jan 2027	C99 Code Emitter & Bare-Metal Compilation	Upcoming
Weeks 19–22	Feb 2027	ESP32 Hardware Deployment & Benchmark vs AIfES	Upcoming
Weeks 23–26	March 2027	Final Documentation, Demonstration, Defense	Upcoming

9.3 Key References

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